

ABSTRACT

Nousiainen, Reetta

Randomness: Contradictions in the Preservation of Built Heritage

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This research examines the contradiction between the goals and practical actions of preserving built heritage. Though strategies and legislation aim to preserve built heritage and promote sustainable development, in practice the action is often the opposite. This study focuses on the situation in Finland at the beginning of the 2020s. The research questions are what societal and cultural factors cause contradictions, how they appear, and what maintains them. The research is situated within the field of museology and multidisciplinary research into built heritage and cultural environment studies.

Grounded theory and two sets of research materials are used in this study. The materials consist of current media articles and expert interviews. The analysis of the data and the integration of the multidisciplinary theoretical literature show that the preservation of built heritage is often subject to randomness.

The research reveals societal structures and cultural practices that lead to and maintain randomness and, thus, contradiction. Especially in the hegemony of the growth economy and consumer culture, environmental issues are secondary. Power and responsibility, as well as rights and obligations, do not go hand in hand. Ambiguity in regulation leads to decisions that depend on individuals or organizations. The decisions concerning built heritage are mostly made in municipalities, but the lack of environmental expertise, dependence on corporate investments, and the weakening of local democracy cause random decisions.

This study shows that such factors lead to decision-making that is contradictory to the goals of built heritage preservation. However, they do not automatically lead to problems in situations where there is the will and expertise to take the built heritage into account. If the situation that enables the contradiction continues or worsens, even exemplary action is subject to randomness.

Keywords: built heritage, building preservation, sustainable development